made worse by growing debt and declining trade. The knock-on effects of the Ukraine conflict have added to the woes, especially when it comes to 3F prices. In many regions, terrorism has been endemic along with its economic costs. Developing societies are also more vulnerable to extreme climate events that we are witnessing with greater frequency. Whether it is the 2030 Agenda or climate commitments, there is growing concern about the ability to sustain progress.

In all of this, India is widely perceived to be an exemplar in many areas. Developing countries also expect a nation like India to articulate their concerns in forums where they may not be present. For India, this is both a moral responsibility as well as an expression of global strategy. After all, the re-balancing process will extend beyond its current beneficiaries, and India is well served by investing deeply in the Global South.

There are also occasions when friends are won and opinions influenced by doing greater good. Some of it again may be directly relevant to national interest. But there is more expected of India as its capabilities grow. In recent years, we have been effective in providing succour in situations ranging from the Türkiye and Nepal earthquakes and Yemen civil war to mudslides in Sri Lanka and floods in Mozambique. The Covid period too saw intensification in international collaboration, be it the Vaccine Maitri for 100 partners, supply of medicines or equipment to 150 countries, or indeed the deployment of Indian personnel in the Maldives, Mauritius, Madagascar, Seychelles, Comoros and Kuwait.

Beyond emergency situations, however, India can help make the world safer and more secure by contributing to the well-being of the global commons. This could take the form of the Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative (IPOI) that India announced at the East Asia Summit in 2019. This has since gathered momentum with a growing list of partnering nations. It could be the Indo-Pacific Partnership for Maritime Domain Awareness (IPMDA), which will focus on challenges like illegal, unreported and unregulated (IUU) fishing. Or indeed the Quad itself, which has taken on responsibilities ranging from collaborative connectivity and pandemic response to emerging and critical technologies. There are also practical examples of demonstrating climate action in which India has played a crucial role. The same spirit drives India’s championing of the International Year of Millets. This could have substantial implications for food security and greener agriculture, especially for Africa.